

Would Rostam and Percy Jackson Be Friends?



EPIC OF KINGS

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Hi! I just started third grade. I also finished the *Percy Jackson and the Olympians* series, and I loved it. Rick Riordan is SUCH a good writer!

I've been thinking a lot about friends lately. This year I'm in the same class as one of my best friends. This is us in kindergarten and on the first day of third grade!

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Kindergarten (left) and third grade (right)!

We've been in the same class every year... well, except second grade. We talked so much in first grade that our teacher split us up! Ha!

But that's okay because I made two awesome new friends that year, so now the four of us are always together! We have some things in common, but we're also pretty different. The cool thing about friends is you don't always have to be alike. Sometimes you can be REALLY different!

So I started to wonder what would happen if Percy time-traveled to the *Shahnameh*. Would Rostam and Percy become friends?

If you're new here, Rostam is the greatest hero in the *Shahnameh*, a Persian epic that is more than a thousand years old.

I know what you're thinking: Percy is a demigod kid, and Rostam is practically 500 years old! How could they ever be friends?!

I wasn't sure at first, but then I remembered something very important... Percy can talk to horses.

Percy Could Talk to Rakhsh!

Percy is the son of Poseidon, who is the god of the sea and also the god of horses. Because of that, Percy can communicate with horses and pegasi. This means Percy could actually talk to Rakhsh!

Rakhsh is Rostam's loyal friend, lifesaver, and horse. In Rostam's first trial, Rakhsh kills a lion while Rostam is sleeping. In the third trial, Rakhsh keeps trying to wake Rostam because he sees a dragon, but the dragon disappears whenever Rostam opens his eyes. Rostam gets annoyed and warns Rakhsh to stop waking him up. Poor Rakhsh. He was trying to save Rostam's life!

I feel like Rakhsh has been waiting a thousand years for someone to hear his side of the story, and Percy would finally be able to listen.

Rakhsh could tell him about the lion, the dragon, and every time Rostam got them both in trouble. Percy could tell Rakhsh about his pegasus friend Blackjack, who calls Percy “boss” and is usually thinking about food. I like Blackjack. He is cool. I think Percy and Rakhsh would become friends pretty quickly, and Blackjack would fit right in. Rostam might take a little longer!

They Both Keep Saving People

But then I started thinking about how loyal Percy and Rostam both are.

Percy cares about his friends so much that Athena says personal loyalty is his fatal flaw. In *The Lightning Thief*, he goes to the Underworld with only three magic pearls for four people: Percy, Annabeth, Grover, and Percy’s mom.

Percy has been trying to rescue his mom for almost the entire book, but he refuses to leave either of his friends behind. He leaves with Annabeth and Grover and promises his mom that he will come back. Percy keeps doing things like this in the other books too. He is always trying to save somebody!

Rostam knows how that goes. His Seven Trials happen because King Kay Kavus ignores important advice, invades Mazandaran, and gets himself and his army captured and blinded by the Divs. Rostam could have just stayed home and relaxed. Instead, he crosses a burning desert, fights a dragon and a witch, defeats Arzhang Div, and enters the terrifying White Div’s cave to rescue everyone.

Percy has to deal with Greek gods who are powerful but don’t necessarily make good decisions. Rostam has Kay Kavus... oh boy. I think they would have a lot to talk about!

They Both Say No to Kings and Gods

At the end of *The Last Olympian*, the gods offer to make Percy immortal, but he turns them down. Instead, he asks the gods to claim all their demigod children and give the children of the minor gods places at Camp Half-Blood.

I think Rostam would respect that. Rostam protects the kings of Iran, but he lets them know that he does it by choice. When Kay Kavus insults Rostam and orders him punished, Rostam gets furious and rides away. Gudarz and the other Persian heroes have to convince Rostam to come back!

But Percy Would Be Mad About Sohrab

Of course, Percy and Rostam would not agree about everything.

Rostam is very serious about his honor and reputation. Percy makes jokes when he is nervous and does not act impressed by powerful people. That might be a little weird at first, but I think their biggest disagreement would be about Sohrab.

Rostam's son Sohrab grows up without his dad. Sohrab knows Rostam is his dad, but he has never met him. When they finally meet in a battle, Sohrab starts to think that the warrior he is about to fight might be Rostam. So Sohrab asks him. But Rostam says no.

Even though Rostam doesn't know Sohrab is his son, he still chooses to hide his identity. I never understood why he lied like that. But anyway, they fight, and Rostam discovers the truth only after he has mortally wounded Sohrab. It's one of the saddest stories I've ever read.

I think Percy would understand Sohrab because Percy also grew up not knowing his dad. At the beginning of *The Lightning Thief*, he doesn't even know which god his father is. So Percy knows what it feels like to wonder if your dad even cares about you. I think Percy would be mad that Rostam lied. Seriously, why didn't Rostam just tell Sohrab his name?

Maybe Rostam would say that they were enemies about to battle and he couldn't give away his identity. Maybe he had another reason. I'm not sure. But I don't think Percy would accept his answer. And honestly, I don't think I would either. That could lead to a HUGE argument. But Percy isn't afraid of powerful people, so I think he would tell Rostam when he thought he was wrong!

So... Would They Be Friends?

I still think YES!

Percy might seem like an annoying kid to Rostam at first. But then Rostam would see Percy risk his life for his friends, stand up to a powerful god, or fight a monster way bigger than him. Rostam would understand what kind of person Percy really was.

They could go on some pretty cool adventures together too! Percy could help Rostam cross an ocean, and Rostam could teach Percy how to fight on a horse. They might argue, but friends can argue sometimes.

And Percy could talk to Rakhsh. I still think that is super important. If Rakhsh trusts Percy, I bet Rostam would too!

What do you think? Would Rostam and Percy become friends?

Thanks for reading. See you next time!

Jack

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